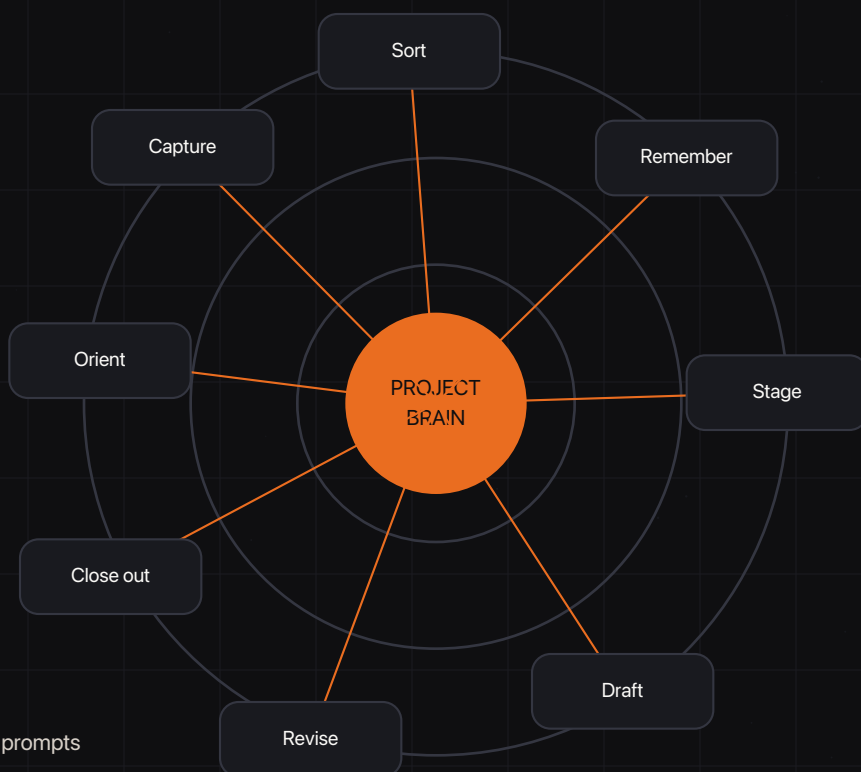


The Writer's AI-Age Flow for a Warm Manuscript

A practical field guide for keeping your book, voice, research, and
next move warm - without handing authorship to AI.



Start here: you are not blocked, you are cold-starting

Most writers do not sit down to a blank page. They sit down to a cold manuscript: a project whose characters, sources, decisions, and open threads cooled off while life happened.

THE OLD DIAGNOSIS

Writer's block

Try harder. Find motivation. Open another tool.
Generate ideas until something sticks.

THE BETTER DIAGNOSIS

Re-entry tax

The book is scattered, so every session begins with archaeology. The fix is manuscript memory, not shame.

USE THIS GUIDE LIKE A FIELD MANUAL

- Do not rebuild your whole writing life. Build one reliable Manuscript Home for one active project.
- Measure organization by one metric: can you resume in five minutes?
- Let AI help as a librarian, continuity clerk, and handoff assistant. The words stay yours.
- Keep this PDF open during setup, then print the quick reference and worksheets.

The 15-minute diagnostic: where your thinking leaks

Check every leak that costs you writing time. Your first system should solve the top two, not everything at once.



The notes graveyard

Useful fragments disappear into five apps and never resurface.



Research misses the page

The quote, passage, or source is somewhere, but finding it costs too much.



Losing the thread

A week away forces you to reread instead of write.



Continuity drift

Characters, timeline, locations, and rules quietly contradict themselves.



Feedback chaos

Editor, beta reader, and writing-group notes arrive in separate places.



The blank page

The page looks empty because the material around it is scattered.

WRITE YOUR TOP TWO LEAKS

1

Leak

What it costs you

2

Leak

What it costs you

Rule: solve the leak that blocks re-entry first. Momentum returns when the book can tell you where you were.

The full flow at a glance

This is the operating loop. AI sits beside it as an assist layer; the writer still owns the compass, the choices, and the sentences.



AI ASSIST LAYER

Memory. Diagnosis. Handoff.

Use AI where it helps you retrieve, compare, question, and prepare. Keep authorship, judgment, and final verification human.

Step 0: set the book compass before you accelerate

A faster workflow amplifies whatever it is pointed at. Define the book before you optimize the making of it.

01 Promise

What will this book deliver?

02 Reader change

What is different after reading?

03 Central question

What tension keeps the book alive?

04 Voice contract

What must the prose sound and feel like?

05 Non-negotiables

What will you not flatten, fake, or outsource?

06 Finish line

What evidence will tell you this draft is done?

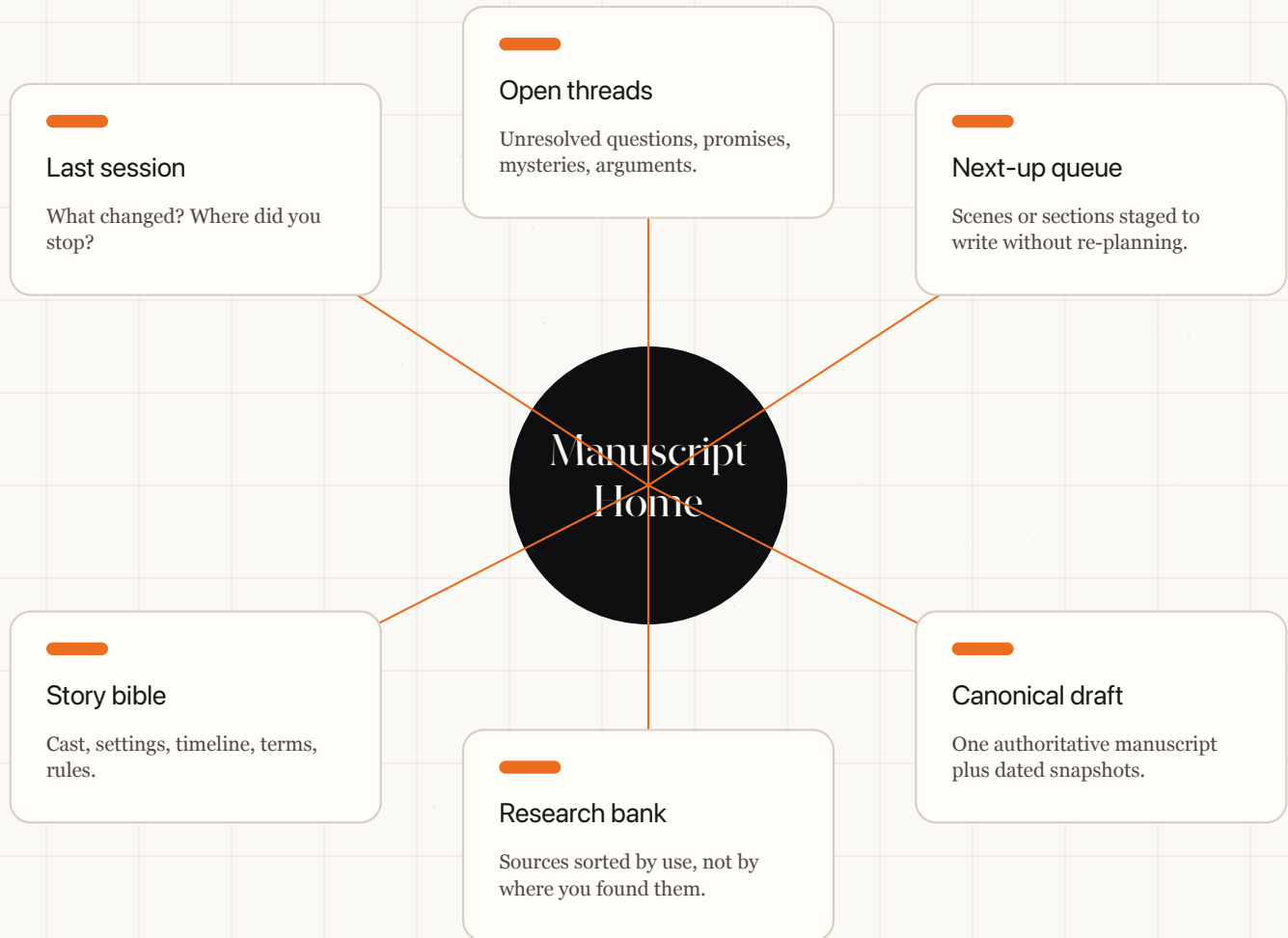
WRITE THE ONE-LINE PROMISE

This book helps _____ move from _____
to _____ by showing / proving / revealing _____.

Keep this sentence visible. Every scene, section, source, and AI request should serve it.

Build a Manuscript Home

A Manuscript Home is the place where the book remembers itself. It is not another folder. It is the current state of the work, kept warm between sessions.



DEFINITION

One canonical draft. One project brain. Dated snapshots before major changes. Organized means future-you knows what is current.

Step 1: capture frictionlessly into one place

Capture should be cheaper than forgetting. The inbox is allowed to be ugly. Its only job is to catch thoughts before they cool.

RULE

One inbox

Voice memo, phone note, paper card, or BuildOS brain dump. Pick one default landing zone for the active manuscript.

DO NOT

Sort while capturing

No tags. No folders. No naming ceremony. Capture first, decide later.

MINIMUM

Capture the edge

A phrase, a question, a contradiction, a line of dialogue, or the scene you realized has to exist.

CAPTURE PROMPTS

☐ Thing I might forget...

☐ Belongs near...

☐ Question to keep alive...

☐ Reader needs to understand...

☐ Do not lose this source...

THE CAPTURE STANDARD

If future-you can understand why the note mattered, it is enough. Capture does not have to be elegant.

Step 2: sort once, deliberately, and later

Do not process every note. Let the inbox cool. Survivors are the notes that still pull on you after time has passed.

THE SURVIVOR TEST

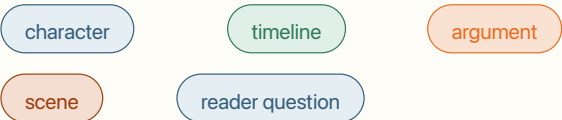
Keep it only if...

- It changes a scene, claim, character, or decision.
- It answers an open question.
- It creates useful tension with something already in the book.
- It is source evidence you can actually use.

THEME BEATS SOURCE

Move it by use

A source folder says where the note came from. A theme bucket says where it can help the draft.



SORT WORKSHEET

INBOX ITEM	USE	DESTINATION	NEXT ACTION

Step 3: keep one project brain

The project brain stores decisions, not just material. This is the difference between a pile of notes and a book that remembers what it has become.

01

Premise and promise

What this book is trying to give the reader.

02

Current draft state

Where the manuscript stands today.

03

Decisions made

Names, timeline choices, cuts, POV rules, argument rulings.

04

Open loops

Questions the book has not resolved yet.

05

Continuity ledger

Names, dates, places, character facts, rules.

06

Handoff packets

What an editor, beta reader, or AI tool needs to know.

WEEKLY PROJECT BRAIN REVIEW

Ask: What did the book learn this week? What decision should never have to be made again? What thread must be visible next time I sit down?

Step 4: stage the next job with curated context

A staged packet helps you, an editor, or an AI tool do one job without reconstructing the whole book. Curated context beats raw context.

CONTEXT PACKET RECIPE

- 1 Job** What you want the tool to do.
- 2 Slice** The specific scene, chapter, source batch, or feedback group.
- 3 Memory** Relevant decisions, style rules, continuity facts, and open loops.
- 4 Guardrails** What must remain yours and what claims need verification.
- 5 Output** The format you need back: checklist, questions, summary, pass plan.

USEFUL ROLE

Librarian

Find the exact note, source, or decision that matters for this scene or claim.

USEFUL ROLE

Continuity clerk

Scan for contradictions in timeline, names, rules, promises, and unresolved threads.

USEFUL ROLE

Handoff assistant

Prepare packets for editors, beta readers, research passes, and revision planning.

Use the AI task map before you prompt

The question is not whether AI is good or bad. The question is which cognitive job you are assigning, what can go wrong, and who owns the final judgment.

GREEN

Delegate the mechanics

- Summarize your own notes
- Retrieve relevant project memory
- Sort feedback into passes
- Compare versions or spot contradictions
- Turn closeouts into re-entry briefs

AMBER

Supervise the thinking

- Generate questions or alternatives
- Suggest structural diagnostics
- Discover possible research leads
- Stress-test an argument or scene
- Draft non-manuscript checklists

RED

Keep the authority

- Your manuscript voice and final prose
- Facts, quotes, citations, and attribution
- Sensitive or unpublished material
- Ethical, legal, or reputational judgment
- The final decision about the book

FOUR-QUESTION GATE

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Could this expose private, licensed, or unpublished material? | ☐ Would I know if the output invented a fact or citation? |
| ☐ Does this job require my taste, voice, or moral judgment? | ☐ Can I describe how I will verify the result before using it? |

If the risk is unclear, reduce the packet, change the job, or keep it human.

Protect the work: voice, privacy, provenance

Speed is useful only if the work remains recognizably yours, the material is handled deliberately, and every published claim can be traced.

VOICE

Build a fingerprint

Choose five pages that sound most like you. Name the rhythm, diction, distance, humor, and moves you refuse. Use it to detect drift - not to imitate yourself mechanically.

PRIVACY

Minimize the packet

Before uploading unpublished work, interviews, client material, or personal data, understand the tool's settings and terms. Share only what the job requires.

PROVENANCE

Trace every claim

AI output is not a source. Open the original, confirm the exact support, record the location, and cite the source you actually checked.

PREFLIGHT BEFORE ANYTHING LEAVES YOUR DESK

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ The final prose sounds like me, not a generic average. | ☐ Every factual claim has an original source I opened. |
| ☐ Every quotation matches the source exactly. | ☐ No sensitive material was shared beyond what I intended. |
| ☐ AI suggestions were treated as options, not authority. | ☐ I can explain the editorial decisions in the final work. |

Authorship test: remove the AI output. Is the central insight, structure, and language still recognizably yours?

Step 5: draft fast from staged material

Drafting is not the time to sort, research, or negotiate the book's identity. Drafting is assembly from material you already staged.

THE DRAFT SPRINT

45 minutes

Open one scene or section packet. Write forward. When a fact is missing, type TK. When a better idea arrives, capture it in the inbox, then return.

SCENE PACKET

- Purpose of scene / section
- What changed before it
- What must change inside it
- Material to use
- Continuity facts
- Exit hook / next beat

BUILD YOUR NEXT THREE PACKETS

	Scene / section	Staged material	Exit beat
1			
2			
3			

USE SEARCHABLE PLACEHOLDERS

TK-FACT [missing fact]

TK-SOURCE [needed evidence]

TK-DECISION [choice later]

Keep drafting now; search every TK in one cleanup pass later.

Step 6: revise with distance

Revision gets chaotic when every problem is handled at once. Build a runway of passes. Each pass has one job.



- 1

Structure

Does the book move in the right order?
- 2

Arc

Does the person, argument, or reader state change?
- 3

Thread

Are promises opened, carried, and resolved?
- 4

Continuity

Do facts, timeline, names, and rules hold?
- 5

Scene

Does each scene earn its space?
- 6

Line

Is the prose clear, alive, and yours?
- 7

Proof

Final correctness after big changes stop.

Feedback is signal, not a verdict. Sort it by pass before you decide what becomes the book.

For fiction: keep the story world warm

World-building is useful only when it changes what characters can do, know, want, or risk. Let the story bible accrete from scenes and consequences.

PEOPLE

Character state

Wants, fears, secrets, loyalties, knowledge, leverage, voice, and the last thing that changed them.

WORLD

Place and systems

Geography, resources, customs, institutions, technology, power, sensory anchors, and hard limits.

CAUSALITY

Time and knowledge

When events happen, who knows what, how information travels, and which consequences are now unavoidable.

SCENE CLOSEOUT -> STORY BIBLE

After drafting a scene, add only what changed. This keeps the bible alive without turning it into a second book.

- ☐ New character fact _____
- ☐ New rule, custom, or constraint _____
- ☐ Power, resource, or relationship shift _____
- ☐ Timeline or knowledge change _____
- ☐ Open promise / mystery _____

For nonfiction: keep the argument warm

The nonfiction version of continuity is claim discipline. Keep sources, claims, examples, and reader objections attached to the part of the draft where they matter.

01

Claim bank

Each claim needs evidence, a counterpoint, and a location in the draft.

02

Source ledger

Track source, useful passage, reliability, and where it supports the argument.

03

Example shelf

Stories, cases, metaphors, and analogies sorted by use.

04

Reader questions

The objections, confusions, and missing context your reader will bring.

RESEARCH-TO-DRAFT CHECK

☐ Changes the argument by...

☐ Belongs near paragraph...

☐ Supports or challenges claim...

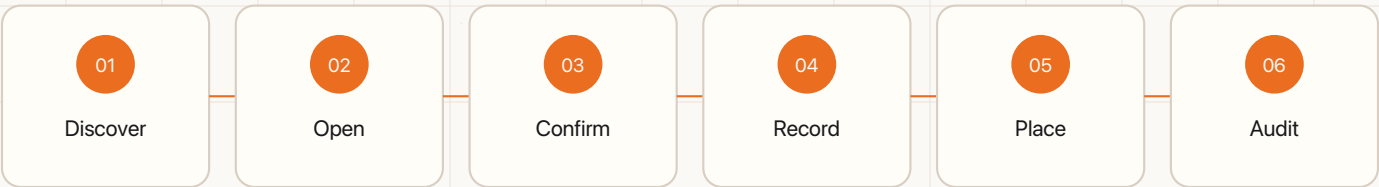
☐ Answers reader objection...

CHAPTER TEST

What changes for the reader here? Name the shift in what they know, believe, feel, or can do. If nothing changes, combine, move, or cut the chapter.

For researched work: build a verification chain

Discovery is not verification. A research workflow is complete only when a claim can travel from manuscript sentence back to exact support in an original source.



CLAIM LEDGER

CLAIM	SOURCE	EXACT SUPPORT	LOCATOR	CHECKED	DRAFT

STATUS RULE

VERIFIED	UNRESOLVED	CUT
Original opened and support logged.	Mark TK and keep it out of final copy.	No support, no claim - however elegant.

Worksheet: the five-minute re-entry brief

Fill this before every writing session. If you cannot fill it, your Manuscript Home needs one more closeout, not another app.

WHERE I STOPPED

WHAT CHANGED LAST SESSION

THE NEXT SCENE / SECTION TO WRITE

RELEVANT MEMORY I NEED LOADED

OPEN QUESTION I SHOULD NOT SOLVE MID-DRAFT

MY EXACT NEXT MOVE

Worksheet: the session closeout

The closeout is how the story stays warm. Spend three minutes here before you stop, especially if the session went well.

I stopped at...

Leave tomorrow a door handle.

The most important thing I learned was...

Decision, insight, source, character fact, or scene problem.

Do not forget...

The fragile thought that will vanish overnight.

Next time, start by...

One concrete action, not a mood.

Add to project memory...

Continuity, source, open thread, or revision task.

FIELD GUIDE

Worksheet: sort feedback without drowning

Do not revise from raw comments. Aggregate the signal first, then decide the pass it belongs to.

FEEDBACK SIGNAL	PATTERN?	PASS	DECISION

Useful pattern test: if two readers are confused in the same neighborhood, believe the confusion. You still choose the fix.

Seven-day setup sprint

Use this if your current system is scattered. Do one small action each day. By day seven, your project has a home and a restart ritual.

DAY 1

Choose one manuscript. Write its promise and finish line.

DAY 2

Create the Manuscript Home, canonical draft, and dated backup.

DAY 3

Choose one inbox. Process 20 notes with the survivor test.

DAY 4

Record current state, decisions, open loops, and continuity.

DAY 5

Stage three packets. Set your green, amber, and red AI rules.

DAY 6

Draft from one packet. Finish with a three-minute closeout.

DAY 7

Re-enter in five minutes, then schedule one revision or verification pass.

Prompt cards: AI that remembers, not writes

Replace the brackets with the smallest useful packet. Keep the instruction narrow, require evidence, and specify the output format.

LIBRARIAN

Using only this context packet, list the notes, sources, or decisions that matter for [scene/section]. Do not write prose. Return missing context as questions.

CONTINUITY CLERK

Scan this packet for contradictions in timeline, names, locations, promises, or world rules. Return a table: issue, evidence, risk, possible fix.

RE-ENTRY ASSISTANT

Turn this closeout into a five-minute re-entry brief. Include where I stopped, what changed, what to load, and the exact next move.

REVISION PLANNER

Sort this feedback into revision passes: structure, arc, thread, continuity, scene, line, proof. Do not rewrite. Give me the next three moves.

SOURCE AUDITOR

For each claim in this packet, identify the cited source and exact support provided. Mark anything missing or indirect as UNVERIFIED. Do not invent citations.

VOICE DRIFT DETECTOR

Compare this passage with my voice fingerprint. Flag shifts in rhythm, diction, distance, or stance. Quote the evidence. Diagnose only; do not rewrite.

Printable quick reference

Keep this page near your desk. It is the whole system compressed.

0

0. Orient

Set promise, reader change, voice contract, and finish line.

1

1. Capture

One inbox. No sorting at capture time.

2

2. Sort

Let notes cool. Keep survivors. Move them by use.

3

3. Remember

Update state, decisions, open loops, sources, and continuity.

4

4. Stage

Build the smallest packet that can do the next job.

5

5. Draft

Write from staged material. Type TK. Keep moving.

6

6. Revise

Run one focused pass at a time, with distance.

7

7. Close out

Record what changed and leave an exact next move.

THE OPERATING PRINCIPLE

Be prolific by losing less.

Slow sort. Fast draft. Verify what matters. Close every session while the book is still warm.

WHERE BUILDOS FITS

A project brain that keeps the book warm

This flow is what BuildOS is built around: talk through messy thinking, and the project becomes structured work with memory. For writers, that means a manuscript home, a re-entry brief, continuity reminders, and context your tools can use without making you paste your whole book into every chat.

BUILDOS HELPS

Capture

Brain dump rough project state, notes, scene problems, and decisions.

BUILDOS HELPS

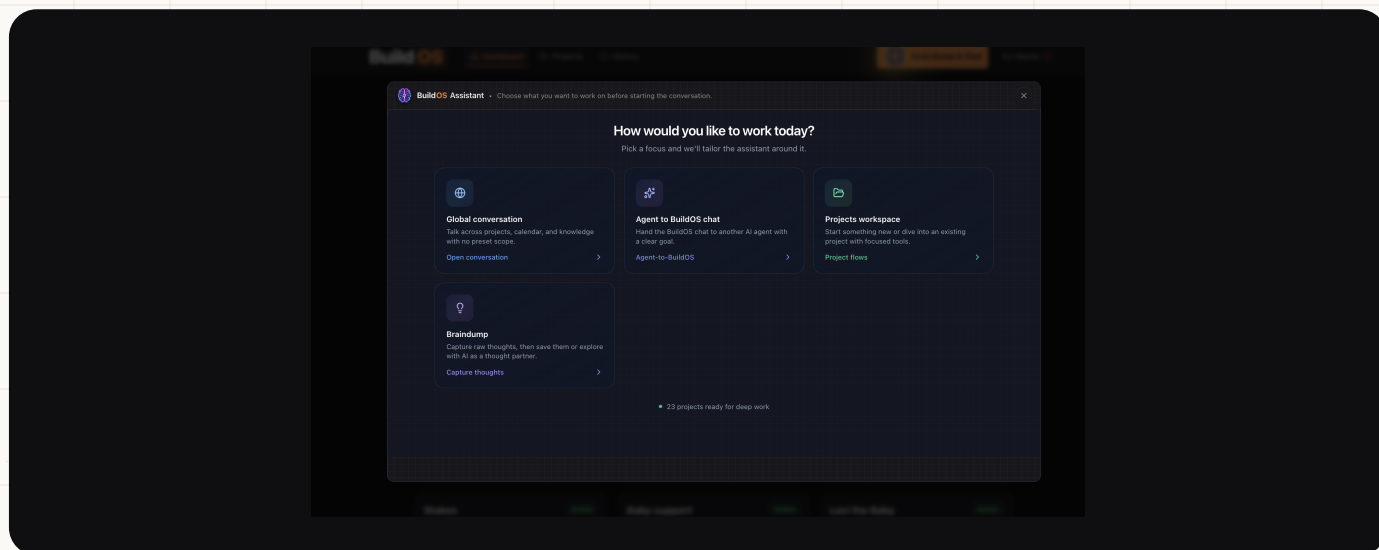
Remember

Keep project memory connected across tasks, docs, risks, and next moves.

BUILDOS HELPS

Resume

Return to the book with the thread already visible.



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